

## Marital Rape

# Silent No Longer

SEX WITHOUT CONSENT IS STILL A LIVING REALITY IN THE INDIAN BEDROOM BUT WOMEN ARE NO LONGER WILLING TO BE STOIC SUFFERERS, ASSERTING INSTEAD, THEIR RIGHT TO DEMAND PLEASURE



■ By Rochona Majumdar

Silence is her only defence, and also the surest reason for collective condemnation." This sentence from an editorial in a leading Kolkata-based English daily described the plight of Priyanka Todi, the widow of a young Muslim graphic designer Rizwanur Rahman, whose tragic death last month has left the city of joy in a state of shock, outrage, and sadness. I read the sentence on a Sunday morning as the sounds of a city getting ready to welcome the goddess Durga—a symbol of female might, agency, and power—filtered through our living room windows. With thousands of Kolkatans and tourists from the world over preparing to marvel at the power and beauty of the

## Has your spouse ever forced you to have sex?

|            |    | MALE | FEMALE |
|------------|----|------|--------|
| Very often | 42 | 38   | 45     |
| Sometimes  | 42 | 46   | 39     |
| Never      | 10 | 11   | 09     |

All figures in per cent. Rest: Don't know/Won't say.

### SEXUAL SPACE

More than three-fourth of all Indian married men believe it's their right to have sex with their wives, more so in cities like Chennai (95%), Ahmedabad (87%) and Lucknow (81%). Of these, 74% fall between the ages of 21 and 30.

goddess Durga, a feminist-minded editorial from an important English mouthpiece urged us to empathise with the fact that young women in this city, even educated, upper-class ones, live in a world of severely circumscribed choices.

This piece of information isn't new. For decades we have been told about the oppressive conditions of Indian women and their silence over it. I am reminded of my own research into the first well-pub-

licised case of a dowry death in 1914 in colonial Bengal. Snehalata Mukhopadhyay, the young woman who set herself afire, had allegedly done so to save her father from the plight of having to cobble together a fat dowry for her forthcoming wedding. Without any records from Mukhopadhyay, as a historian, I had to make sense of the babble of voices that rocked the Bengali public sphere. As feminist scholars we learn to acknowledge that women's silences speak

volumes. Our task as commentators and social analysts is to weave narratives of their pain by trying to make sense of the reasons that rendered them mute.

But is this still the historian's predicament today? Do we have to go on reading women's "silences" because their "voices" have not been recorded? Might we not entertain the hope, even if briefly, that a new breed of Indian women may have begun to speak their minds? The INDIA TODAY AC Nielsen-